EARLY DETECTION: BEST DEFENSE AGAINST BREAST CANCER



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Breast cancer presents a formidable global health challenge, affecting both men and women. The mounting cases of breast cancer in the country are a cause for concern each year. In India, the lifetime risk of breast cancer for women stands at 1 in every 25-30 A particularly alarming statistic reveals that 50% of women within a population of one lakh face the potential threat of breast cancer. Furthermore, the disease carries a high mortality rate, with one death occurring for every two women diagnosed with breast cancer. This serves as a stark reminder that early detection plays a pivotal role in ensuring effective treatment.

One of the foremost challenges in India is the delayed diagnosis of breast cancer, especially in tier 2, tier 3, and tier 4 cities. Given the limited prevalence of routine breast cancer screenings, patients often seek medical assistance only when the cancer has reached an advanced stage.

Advanced stages of breast cancer are notably more challenging to treat, particularly in remote areas where access to advanced medical facilities remains restricted. Stigma and a lack of awareness further contribute to this delay in seeking treatment. Surprisingly, even among the literate and well-to-do urban families, some individuals hesitate to seek medical help due to the stigma associated with the disease. Such hesitancy results in late-stage diagnoses and poorer treatment outcomes, ultimately contributing to the increased mortality rate, which currently stands at 1 in 2 patients. It is important to note that early intervention, even at stage 2, can result in curable outcomes with an 85% success rate.

CAUSATIVE FACTORS AND RISKS

While a singular identifiable cause remains elusive, several risk factors, such as lifestyle changes, an unhealthy diet, physical inactivity, and obesity, play a pivotal role in breast cancer development. Hormonal changes also significantly contribute to breast cancer, with 90% of cases linked to hormonal factors in women.

EARLY DETECTION FOR ENHANCED TREATMENT OUTCOMES:

Preventive measures are crucial, and individuals can take proactive steps to reduce their risk. Regular breast care examinations, beginning as early as age 21-25, facilitate the early detection of symptoms. Genetic screening is especially vital for those with a family history of breast cancer, while mammograms are recommended for women above 40 as an annual screening tool. Maintaining a healthy lifestyle is equally essential in reducing the risk of breast cancer.

HOLISTIC APPROACH TO BREAST CANCER TREATMENT:

Between 1975 and 2016, the five-year survival rate improved by 36% in India, primarily owing to more targeted therapies and immunotherapies. These advancements have not only enhanced survival rates for certain cancers, such as breast and lung cancers but also improved the quality of life. Various techniques in breast oncology treatment, including sentinel lymph node biopsy, axillary surgery, prophylactic mastectomy, modified radical mastectomy, skin-sparing and nipple-sparing mastectomy, breast conservation surgery, oncoplasty, oncology/breast reconstruction, LD/LICAP, and TDAP reconstruction, are available to patients to combat breast cancer.

The progress in technology and medical treatments offers hope in the battle against breast cancer. Early detection increases the likelihood of a successful cure, even for advanced-stage cancers. It is essential to debunk misconceptions surrounding breast cancer, such as the outdated belief that treatment involves the complete removal of the breast. At MGM Cancer Institute, we offer precise pathology and lab services for effective disease diagnosis, contributing to well-informed treatment planning across medical, surgical, and radiation oncology. Drawing upon 25 years of data and research, we advocate breast conservation through oncoplasty, integrating plastic surgery techniques without compromising oncological principles. This approach not only yields superior aesthetic outcomes but also enhances the psycho-social well-being of patients. This is especially pertinent given that the number of young women with breast cancer in India is nearly double that in the western world.

A PERSONALIZED APPROACH TO BREAST CANCER TREATMENT:

In the current era of personalized medicine, no two cases of breast cancer are identical. We tailor the treatment, surgery, and medications to align with the tumor's unique characteristics. In recent cases we've treated, we have witnessed remarkable outcomes. For instance, one patient, diagnosed with an 8-9 cm breast tumor just two years into her marriage, saw her tumor shrink to 1 cm with chemotherapy, allowing us to conserve her breast. In another case where the tumor couldn't be significantly reduced, we performed a nipple-sparing mastectomy, preserving the outer part of the breast while replacing the inner side with autologous tissue from the same patient.

We also conduct genetic mapping of patients and implement risk-reducing strategies and surgeries when high-risk genes are identified. Our comprehensive approach extends beyond treatment, addressing emotional needs through psycho-oncologists, dietary requirements through nutrition and dietetics specialists, and post-operative care through rehabilitation specialists, among other aspects.

A CALL TO ACTION:

The escalating incidence of breast cancer in India compels a collective call to action. We all share a responsibility to address the challenges of late-stage diagnosis, stigma, and a lack of awareness. Early detection through regular screenings and the adoption of a healthy lifestyle can significantly diminish the risk of breast cancer. With knowledge and action, we can collaboratively work toward reducing the prevalence of breast cancer and enhancing outcomes for those affected by it.